Lesson 24: Grammar: Gerunds and Infinitives

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 2: Getting to Know You

Adapted from Getting to Know You - An Intermediate Integrated-Skills Module for English Learners by Sara Ferguson, Grossmont College (CC BY-NC-SA): Grammar: Using Gerunds and Infinitives for Sentence Variety.

In this lesson

You will learn what gerunds (reading) and infinitives (to read) are, and how they work like nouns in a sentence. You will learn which verbs take a gerund, which take an infinitive, and which can take both. Then you will use them to make your writing more varied and more formal.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Form gerunds (verb + -ing) and infinitives (to + verb).
- Tell the difference between a gerund and an -ing verb ("Hiking is fun" / "They are hiking").
- Use a gerund as a subject, as the object of a verb, and after a preposition.
- Choose a gerund or an infinitive after common verbs (enjoy eating, promise to study).
- Write a short paragraph about a person with gerunds and infinitives.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
gerund	verb + -ing that works like a noun	I like reading.
infinitive	to + the base form of a verb; it works like a noun	I like to read.
base form	the simple form of a verb, with no ending	talk, read, say
subject	the person or thing that does the action; usually at the start of the sentence	Being grateful can improve our sense of well-being.
object of a verb	the word or words after the verb that receive the action	She enjoys eating chocolate.
preposition	a small word like on, in, by, about, to	Another method to boost happiness is by using our strengths.
linking verb	a verb like be, seem or appear; it links the subject to an adjective	It's important to notice the good things in life.
sentence variety	using different kinds of sentences	Gerunds and infinitives add sentence variety.

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
formal	serious and careful, for school and work	Gerunds and infinitives make your writing more formal and academic.
boost	to make bigger or stronger	In order to boost happiness, there are five methods people can use.
optimistic	thinking that good things will happen	Be optimistic.
look forward to	to feel happy about something in the future	What are you looking forward to doing tomorrow?

Rules and explanations

Gerunds

- Form: base form + -ing: talking, reading, saying.
- A gerund is **not** the verb of the sentence. It works like a noun.
- An **-ing verb** is part of a continuous tense: it follows the subject and comes after am, is or are. People feel happier when they are using their natural abilities. ("are using" = verb)
- A **gerund** works like a noun. Another method to boost happiness is by using our strengths. ("using" = gerund, after the preposition "by")
- Like a noun, a gerund can be:
  - the **subject**: Gerund + verb + object. Being grateful can improve our sense of well-being.
  - the **object of a verb**: Subject + verb + gerund. She enjoys eating chocolate.
  - the **object of a preposition**: Subject + verb + preposition + gerund. ... is by using our strengths.
  - at the start, after a preposition: Preposition + gerund + subject + verb.

Infinitives

- Form: to + base form: to talk, to read, to say.
- An infinitive is **not** the verb of the sentence. It works like a noun.
- Two common patterns:
  - Subject + verb + infinitive: We should always try to keep a positive attitude.
  - It + linking verb + adjective + infinitive: It's important to notice the good things in life.

Which verbs take which form?

Some verbs take a gerund, some take an infinitive, and some can take both.

- I like reading. / I like to read. (both are correct)
- I promise to study. (NOT: I promise studying.)
- She enjoys eating chocolate. (NOT: She enjoys to eat chocolate.)

Followed by a gerund	Followed by an infinitive	Either, with little change in meaning	Either, with a different meaning
dislike, appreciate, enjoy, (not) face, look forward to, consider, imagine, recall, miss, recommend, admit (to), deny, describe, mention, prohibit, report, suggest, postpone, delay, put off, risk, avoid, mean (= involve), practice, go	would like, expect, hope, need, agree, appear / seem, ask, get (be allowed), offer, refuse, plan, wait, promise, intend, tend, afford	like, love, cannot bear / cannot stand, prefer, hate, continue, begin / start	remember, forget, try, stop, regret

- The last group (remember, forget, try, stop, regret) **changes meaning** with a gerund or an infinitive. Ask your tutor to explain (see "Speak with your tutor").

Why use gerunds and infinitives?

They make your writing better because they:

- add sentence variety
- help you develop your ideas
- make your writing more formal and academic

Practice

1. Gerund or verb? Is "hiking" the verb in each sentence? How do you know? a) Hiking is one of his favorite activities. b) They are hiking in the mountains today.

2. What does the gerund do? Is the gerund the subject of the verb, the object of the verb, or the object of a preposition? a) Mentoring other employees is his favorite part of the job. b) Her decision to major in medicine was based on volunteering at the hospital. c) They love inspiring other students at the college.

3. Find the verb and the infinitive. a) After he finishes college, he wants to work as a geologist. b) It's important to listen during an interview.

4. Compare two paragraphs. Read Paragraph 1 and Paragraph 2 (about five ways to be happy) in your lesson material. Then answer: a) What verb forms does the first paragraph use? What person (you, he/she/it, we/they) does each paragraph use? b) Which paragraph is more formal and sophisticated? Why? c) The second paragraph is more developed. What did the author do to develop the ideas more completely? d) Find all the gerunds and infinitives in the second paragraph.

5. About you. Answer each question in a full sentence. Use the table to choose a gerund or an infinitive.

1. What do you like to do in your free time?
2. Describe your favorite memory from your childhood. What do you remember doing?
3. What activity have you tried and failed to do?
4. What movies or TV shows do you recommend seeing?
5. What do you hope to do next year? In five years?

6. What do you dislike most about your everyday routine? Why?
7. What are you looking forward to doing tomorrow?

6. About another person. Ask your tutor to play a friend or family member, and ask the seven questions in exercise 5. Take notes. Then write the paragraph in "Writing task".

Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me the seven questions from my lesson, one at a time. Correct my gerunds and infinitives."
- "Please explain the difference between 'I stopped to talk' and 'I stopped talking'. Do the same for remember, forget, try and regret. Give one example for each, then test me."
- "Give me verbs from this list, one at a time: enjoy, hope, avoid, plan, practice, refuse, consider, afford. I will make a true sentence about my life with each one."
- "Ask me how I boost my happiness. I will answer with 'by + -ing' and 'It's important to...'."

Read aloud

- Hiking is one of his favorite activities. (↘)
- They are hiking in the mountains today. (↘)
- Mentoring other employees is his favorite part of the job. (↘)
- After he finishes college, he wants to work as a geologist. (↘)
- It's important to listen during an interview. (↘)
- She enjoys eating chocolate. (↘)
- What do you like to do in your free time? (↘)
- What are you looking forward to doing tomorrow? (↘)

Writing task

Write a short paragraph about your tutor's character (a friend or family member), using your notes from exercise 6.

- At least **six sentences**.
- Use the **third person** (he or she, and the person's name).
- Use **gerunds and infinitives**. Use the table to decide if each verb takes a gerund or an infinitive.
- Try to use verbs from the questions: like, remember, try, recommend, hope, dislike, look forward to.
- Read your paragraph aloud and check every verb + gerund or verb + infinitive.

Watch online

- The book's slide presentation of this lesson: https://docs.google.com/presentation/d/e/2PACX-1vRGlL8tGaXw-tX3zikKsSeUoaeJH2BmfUW79FRchg-nQ3IkJwpBBJ2i-a0qS6x1rZ2xcayLLWGB6JGe/embed

Answer key

1. (book, corrected: in b the book writes "am" by mistake) a) "Hiking" is a gerund. It does not come after "be", and it is the subject of the sentence. The verb is "is". b) "Hiking" is a verb. It comes after "be" (are) and follows the subject.

2. (book) a) "Mentoring" is the subject of the verb "is". b) "Volunteering" is the object of the preposition "on". c) "Inspiring" is the object of the verb "love".

3. (book) a) verb: wants; infinitive: to work. b) verb: is; infinitive: to listen.

4. (book) a) The first paragraph uses the second person (you). It uses one modal, "should", and the imperative. The second paragraph uses the first person plural (we) and the third person plural (they). It uses gerunds, infinitives and a variety of modals. b) The second paragraph. It is more formal because it uses "we" and the third person, and it is more sophisticated because it has more sentence variety. c) The author gave specific examples. d) to boost, being, to say, praying, meditating, to notice, writing, to count, to be, to keep, to boost, using, committing, increasing.

5. (example answer)

1. In my free time, I like to read. (or: I like reading.)
2. I remember playing football with my cousins in the street.
3. I tried to learn to swim, but I failed.
4. I recommend seeing nature documentaries.
5. Next year, I hope to find a better job. In five years, I hope to have my own business.
6. I dislike getting up early, because I am always tired.
7. Tomorrow, I am looking forward to meeting my friends.

6. (example answer) My friend Omar enjoys reading history books in his free time. He remembers fishing with his father at the lake when he was a child. He tried to learn the guitar, but he gave up after two months. He recommends watching nature documentaries, because they are beautiful and educational. Next year, he hopes to start a master's degree, and in five years he plans to open his own business. He dislikes waiting for the bus every morning, because it is often late. Tomorrow, he is looking forward to having dinner with his family.

My notes